was to threaten Dirang Dzong and Bomdila by getting to the 9-kilometre and 31-kilometre points on the Bomdila-Dirang road by 17 November. Simultaneously, other battalions of 419 Tibetan Unit were also on the move, with the objective of cutting off both Bridge 1 and Bridge 2 between Se-la and Dirang. While one battalion moved via Chabra-la and Jangle, the other followed the Yonggyap-la and Nyukmadong track.

China's 11 Division, under the command of General Yu Zhi Guo, with its 32 and 33 Regiments, had begun probing the Se-la defences from the direction of Dzalung-la; the Chinese patrols from this unit were tasked with shadowing Indian patrols to determine the exact layout of the Indian defences. Jitter parties were sent out to unnerve the Indians and draw them out into the open where they could be annihilated. Meanwhile, the second battalion of this division was to take on 4 Garhwal Rifles at Nuranang. The main frontal attack on Se-la was to be launched by the Chinese 55 Division that was under the command of General Liu Gueng. D-Day for this was 18 November, and going by the brief fight at Bum-la with 1 Sikh, the Chinese knew that Se-la, should the Indians choose to fight, would be a hard, if not impossible, nut to crack.

ON THE FLANKS OF SE-LA

When 4 Rajput was in Belgaum preparing to move to Sikkim it received orders to proceed to NEFA immediately. Major Trilok Nath was the officiating commanding officer as Lieutenant Colonel Prem Lal had moved as the AAG to IV Corps and his replacement was still with the UN in Laos. On 24 October, a day after detraining at Missamari, Nath was told that the battalion was now a part of 65 Infantry Brigade under the command of Brigadier G. M. Saeed. At the time, there was total confusion in Missamari and with great difficulty and with the help of their erstwhile CO, Prem Lal, the battalion managed to organize transport and started moving towards Bomdila where it was to occupy the left flank while 1 Madras was to situate itself on the right shoulder.

Once they reached Bomdila on 27 October, 4 Rajput was told to proceed to Dirang Dzong, as 1 Sikh LI had been detailed for the defence of Bomdila. Nath immediately left for a detailed reconnaissance of the areas around Thembang, Dirang Dzong, Manda-la and Phudong. Just then 4 Division HQ asked one company of 4 Rajput to immediately rush to Dirang